Khrushchev withdrew Soviet advisers in China and terminated nuclear cooperation, including the promised transfer of nuclear weapons.

China's relationship with the US, too, is a tangled history. In the late 1890s, the US had protected Chinese unity. As the European colonial powers and Japan eyed China for their commercial purposes, Washington insisted on a policy that kept the mainland open to trade and investment, preventing any single power from carving out a sphere of influence within it. American interests were selfish – Washington wanted to ensure that it would have unfettered access not only for its businesses but also for its Christian missionaries. Selfish or not, US policy helped preserve China's unity when the Europeans and Japanese were spoiling to divide it. When in 1937 the Japanese invaded Manchuria in northern China, Washington once again moved to protect Chinese unity. It condemned Tokyo's action and provided the Chinese with military and economic aid. In the Pacific war against Japan from December 1941 onward, Chiang Kai-shek was an ally. The US later recognized the special relationship by insisting that China be made a Permanent Member of the UN Security Council despite opposition from the UK. Indeed, Washington ensured that the first country to sign the UN Charter was Chiang's China, arguing that it had played a vital part in the war against Germany, Italy, and Japan.

Washington's closeness to Chiang Kai-shek and dislike of communism did not stop it from developing relations with Mao and the CPC. Joe Stillwell, the American general of Second World War fame, went so far as to argue that the CPC was a better political and military force than the corrupt KMT. Various US military envoys tried to broker cooperation between the CPC and the KMT. While US President Truman strove to keep the door to the communists open, developments in Korea led to its closing for the next two decades. In late November 1950, as UN troops under US leadership pushed the invading North Korean forces all the way back to the border with China, Beijing acted. It threw millions of troops at the UN forces, causing them to retreat down the peninsula. Relations with the US worsened even further when China shelled Taiwan across the straits in